JAZZ LAB

LEARN CREATIVELY.

- TRANSCRIPTIONS
- IMPROVISATION
- PRACTICE
- CREATIVITY





7 STEPS FOR THE CREATIVE IMPROVISER

THE 21ST CENTURY MUSICIAN SERIES



7 STEPS

FOR THE CREATIVE IMPROVISER



www.jazzlabmusic.org

by Henrique Eisenmann, Tim Lienhard and the jazz lab family.

INTRO

by Henrique Eisenmann

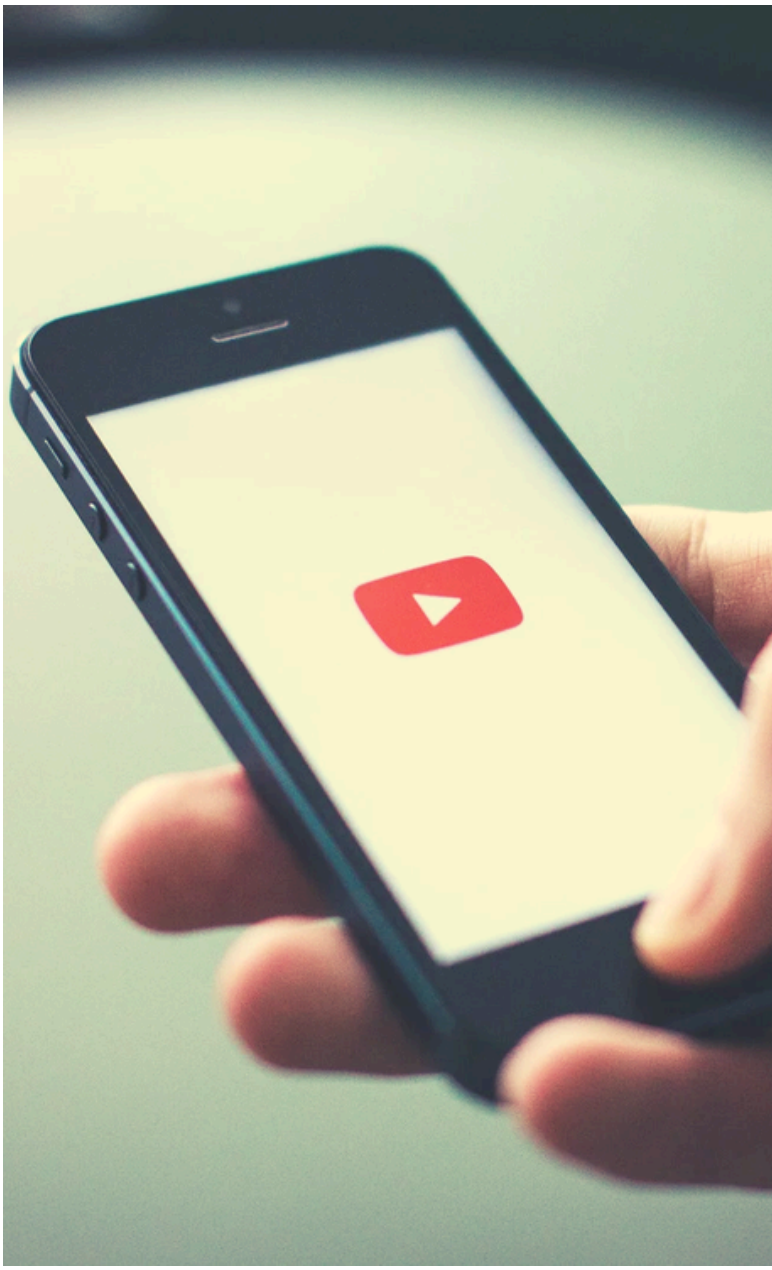


Improvisation is one of the most powerful, honest and deep ways to express one's thoughts and emotions through music. Current Jazz education often sees improvisation as an organized set of theoretical rules with a specific grammar, syntax and semantics. As a result, many modern improvisers spend the majority of their time working on chord-scales, finger patterns, intricate transcriptions and empty virtuosismo.

It is possible, however, to explore improvisation as a different type of musical intelligence that enables musicians to express a wider set of emotions, using a methodology that is not restricted to jazz, and can be acquired and mastered by any musician, with the help of knowledge in music history, technique, ear training and familiarity with repertoire.

#1 - 30 MINUTES OF YOUTUBE PER DAY

AT LEAST 30 minutes of Youtube per day.....



Use Youtube as a music research tool: start by watching/listening to something familiar, moving towards unknown styles/artists. (the suggested videos column is a great way to start discovering, you may start with some Charles Mingus, and ten minutes later you will be checking out some Mongolian throat singing)...

Save your discoveries on playlists; I have more than 50 different playlists with my "discoveries", artists, recordings, solos that I love, and other ideas that may help improve my creativity in the future.

Share your playlists with friends, so you can expand your "palette" faster and create a community of people checking out the same music.

#2 - START YOUR PRACTICE BY PLAYING FREE

It may seem counter-productive, but it is not: playing free is the best way to connect to our inner creativity and train our ears. Start your practice by playing at least 10 minutes of completely FREE music. 10 minutes is a long time, so it will force you to dive deep into our creative mind, and accept the unknown, the less expected.

Record all your free improvisations on your phone as voice memos.

It is hard to listen to ourselves playing free, there's a lot of frustration. However, try to concentrate on the moments in which you sounded good. The title of your voice memo can specify the minute in which you had a good idea (for example "check out the chord on 3'15"), you will be surprised by how many good ideas you will come up with.



#3 - CREATE A DICTIONARY OF CREATIVE IDEAS

Carry a music notebook with you everywhere, in which you will notate every good musical idea you hear. For example, cool chords, interesting melodies, a harmonic progression, a crazy rhythmic pattern; after some time you will have an incredible list of great ideas.



When I was 16, I started asking every musician I knew - from friends to famous artists - for their favorite chord. I would ask them to write it on my notebook. Instead of autographs, I had hundreds of amazing unique chords. (Chick Corea's and Oscar Peterson's are my favorites). Nowadays, my notebook became a true dictionary of incredible chords. Every day when I'm practicing or arranging something, I collect some cool ideas from my dictionary.

Remember, your Free Improvised-voice memos are a great source of ideas for your dictionary. This will dramatically expand your creative potential when improvising.

#4 - LISTEN TO WEIRD MUSIC



Listening exclusively to mainstream music is never going to make your artistic voice truly unique.

We are a result of the weird music we listen to.

All our favorite musicians have their collections of weird music they check out. Get familiar with some Contemporary Classical music and World Music.
Listen to Stravinsky (Firebird, Rite of Spring), Bartok (Concerto for Orchestra, String Quartet No. 4,5,6), Olivier Messiaen (Quartet for the End of Time, Preludes), etc. Get familiar with some Balkan music (Ivo Papasov), Brazilian Music (**Hermeto Pascoal***), Pakistan (Nusrat Fateh Ali Khan), Mali (Ali Farka Touré).

***CHECK OUT OUR FESH TRANSCRIPTION OF HERMETO PASCOAL's "TAYNARA" AT THE END OF THIS E-BOOK.**
https://youtu.be/h5l-FpWxia0

#5 - IMPROVISE SOUNDTRACKS TO MOVIES

Choose different movies/tv shows, mute the audio and improvise the soundtracks. Try to change the meaning of a scene by changing the music behind. This is an exercise to practice your ability to express emotional material in your music.



My favorite exercise is to take a horror movie and try to transform it into a comedy by improvising the music. Or you can do the opposite, pick a comedy movie and transform it into a drama.

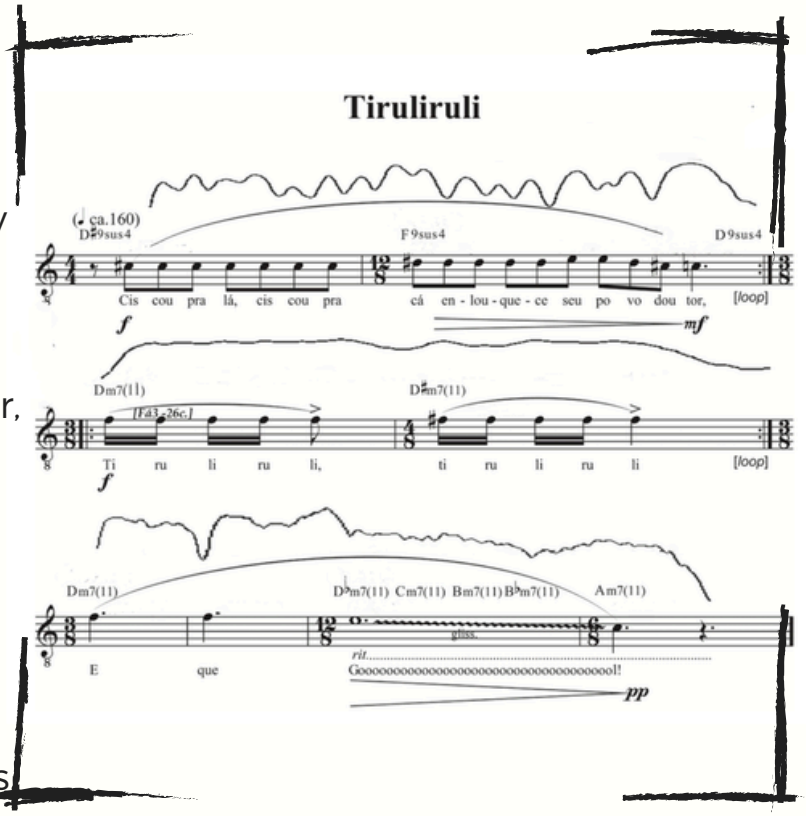
You will then notice the importance of developing vocabulary to express different types of emotions in your music. Simply using fancy chords or scales won't be enough. You need repertoire, different ideas, imagination and aesthetic intelligence.

A great solo is not only a good collection of pitches and chord, but also an emotional narrative. And this is a skill that can be practiced.

#6 - PAY ATTENTION TO SPOKEN VOICES

Spoken voices are filled with interesting melodic contours and rhythmic ideas that we would rarely come up in our regular music playing.

Before Charles Cornell was recording his videos, many other composers were already exploring the melodies of spoken voice. Check out this transcription of an amazing piece that uses the voice of a sports narrator,


Tiruliruli
(♩ ca.160)
D♯9sus4
F9sus4
D9sus4
Cis cou pra lá, cis cou pra
cá en - lou - que - ce seu po vo dou tor,
[loop]
f
mf
Dm7(11)
D♯m7(11)
[Fa3-26c.]
Ti ru li ru li,
ti ru li ru li
[loop]
f
Dm7(11)
D♭m7(11) Cm7(11) Bm7(11) B♭m7(11)
Am7(11)
gliss.
rit.
E que
Goooooo

#7 - BREAK THE RULES (IN A SMART WAY)

Study the grammar of Jazz (theory, chords, transcriptions, analysis) in order to know how to break them.

Only break the rules once you understand why they exist.
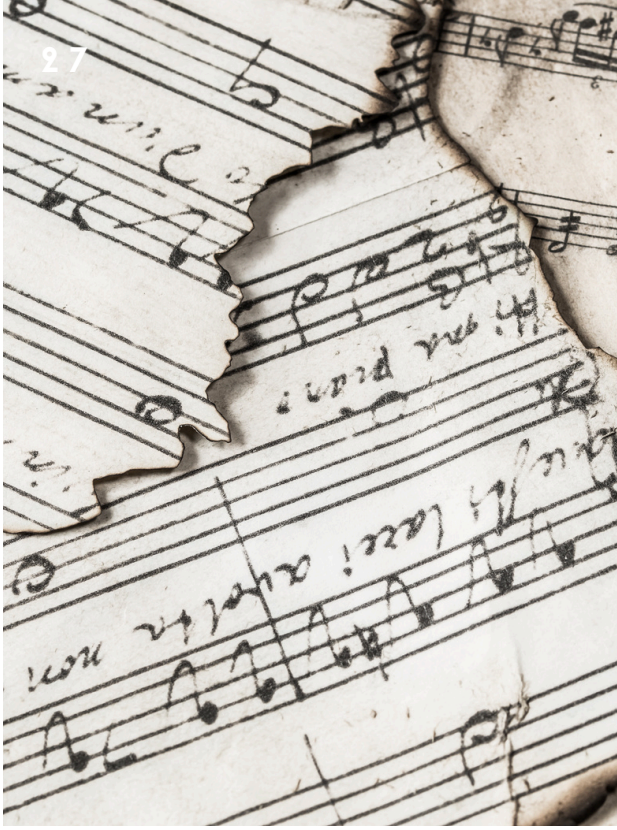


Explore "creative constraints" - create your own rules to practice improvisation:

- Improvise using only a limited number of pitches (or a small range)
- Use only a specific rhythm (upbeats, tuplets, or a motive that you keep repeating).
- Use only specific types of scales, or tensions for each chord.

Creating your own set of rules helps to develop your creativity and ability to solve problems. It's like training to run on the sand, so that you get stronger to run on a normal floor.

MUSICAL

DISCOVERY



In the spirit of discovering some new music, below you can find an exclusive transcription of Hermeto Pascoal's "Taynara" (here is the recording: https://youtu.be/h5l-EpWxia0). This is a Brazilian contemporary piece in 7/8, filled with rhythmic and melodic challenges. Any instrumentalist/vocalist can learn it and perform it using the leadsheet below.

Playing this piece will improve your ability to improvise over ODD meters, modal improvisation, hand coordination, building grooves and mastering syncopation.
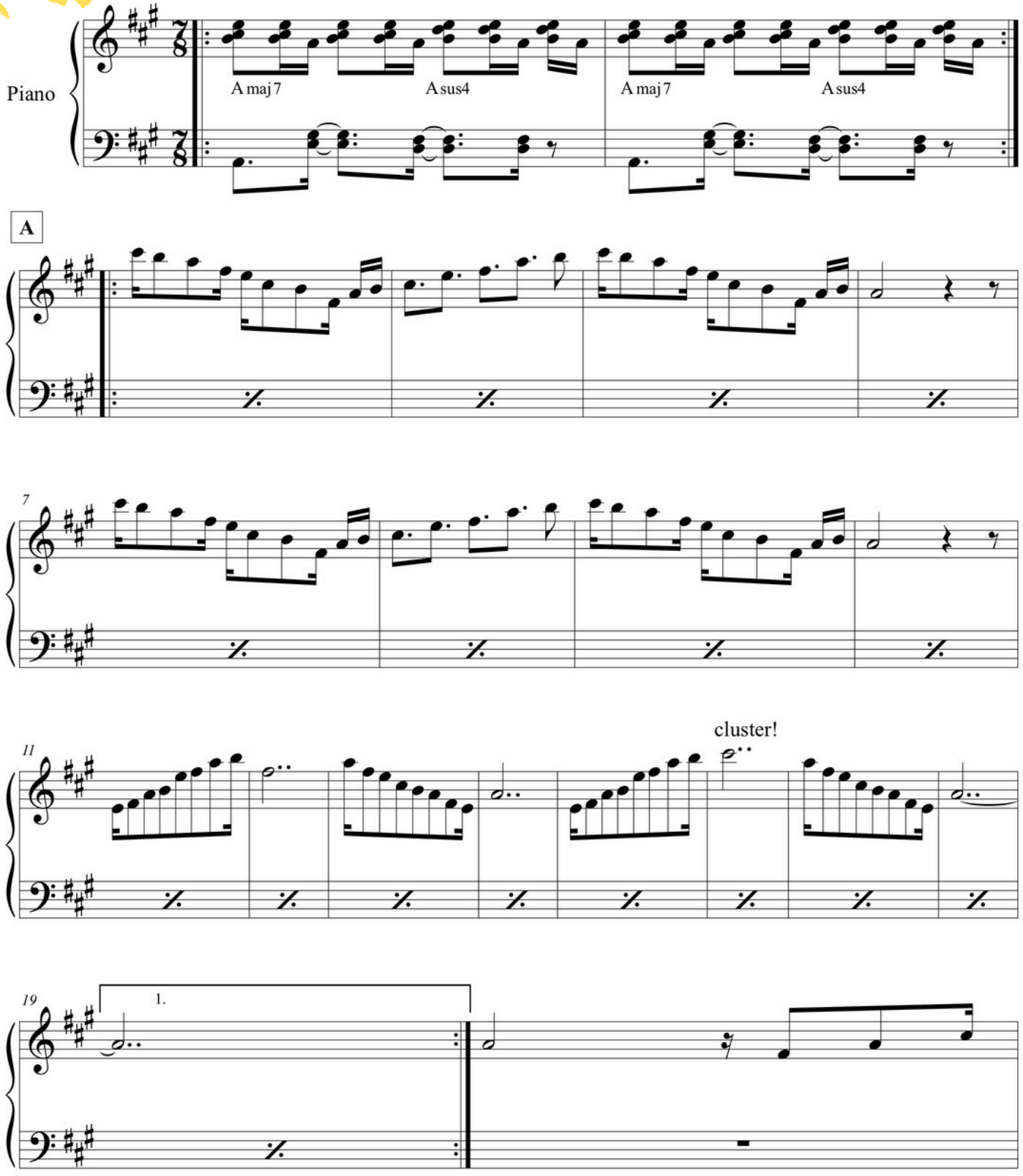


Challenges:

- **play the melody while taping quarter notes in your feet**
- **try harmonizing this melody by starting it on another pitch of the A major scale**
- **sing the melody while clapping the bass pattern**
- **improvise using only the rhythmic motive from the A section melody**

TRANSCRIPTION
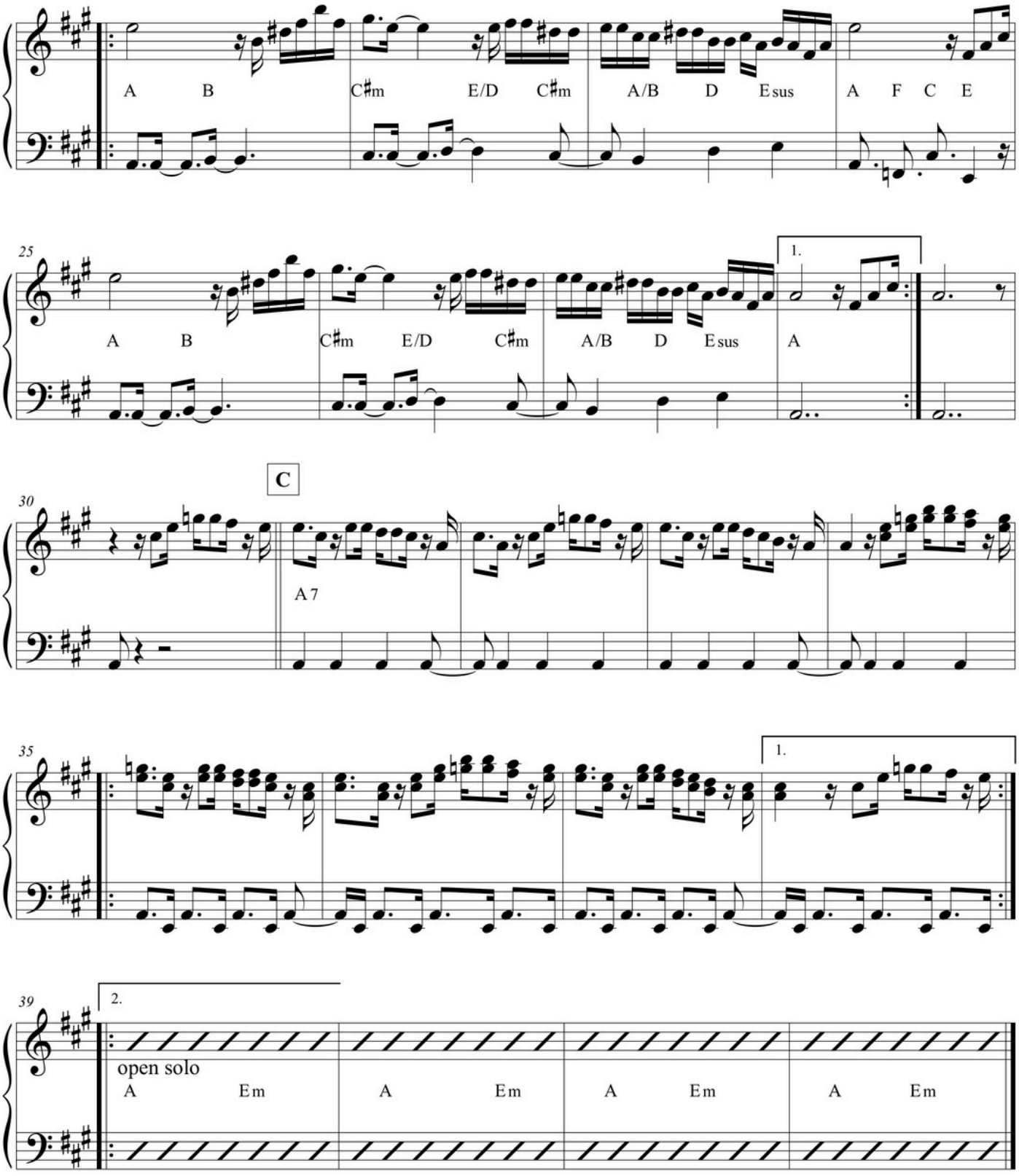
Taynara

Hermeto Pascoal
Transcription Henrique Eisenmann



Taynara

B


A B C♯m E/D C♯m A/B D Esus A F C E
25
A B C♯m E/D C♯m A/B D Esus
1.
A
30
C
A7
35
1.
39
2.
open solo
A Em A Em A Em A Em